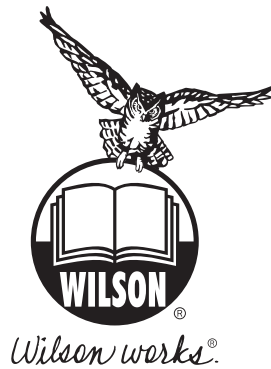


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The Life of a Star

Did you ever look up into the sky and hear yourself asking, “What exactly is a star?” Well, a star is a massive sphere made of very hot gas. A star is mostly made of hydrogen gas, and it’s held together by its own force of gravity.

If you were to take a long tour of space, you would discover that there are about 200 - 400 billion stars in the Milky Way alone. However, these numbers constantly change as new stars are born and old ones turn to dust. Some of these stars are quite big and some are much smaller. They range in color depending upon how hot they are. They can be brown, red, orange, yellow, white, or blue.

To be exact, our own Sun is a star. It's not the most gigantic sort of star to exist, but it's absolutely not the smallest kind either. The Sun turns in a different direction than the Earth, and it takes only eight minutes for the light from the Sun to make its way to our planet. The Sun was born about 4.6 billion years ago, but don't be sad about this poor old ball of gas. It will live for another 5 billion years!

Sharks PART ONE

The thought of a shark may either scare or thrill you. Whatever you think about sharks, there's one fact that you cannot ignore. There's a lot to discover about these ocean animals.

First, you may be asking yourself whether a shark is a mammal or a reptile. The smart answer is that sharks are neither mammals nor reptiles. As it turns out, sharks are fish!

Sharks live in every ocean on Earth and they have done so for about 455 million years. They have adapted to many different parts of the ocean. Some sharks spend their time close to the top of the water while other sharks swim and hunt along the ocean floor.

Sharks are different from other kinds of fish because their skeletons are not made of bone. Sharks have special scales that help them move quickly through the water. However, their fins are stiff so they can swim in only one direction.

You may have heard that sharks come in all shapes and lengths, but did you know that the smallest shark is only six inches long? On the other hand, there is a shark called the whale shark that can be as long as 41 feet! These gigantic sharks live quite a bit longer than the smaller kinds of sharks.

Sharks PART ONE

Looking to discover more about the magnificent ocean animals called sharks? Here are some additional facts to explore.

Most sharks have somewhere between 40 and 45 teeth. Sharks lose their teeth quite often and can go through 30,000 teeth from birth to the end of their lives.

You won't ever find a shark in the middle of a nap because they don't sleep. Yes, you heard that right! Sharks swim at all times. A shark must constantly pump water into its body to keep itself alive, but at times they do "rest" and swim at the same time.

Scientists think sharks are color-blind, but very much like cats, they have good vision in the dark. Sharks, unlike other fish, have lids that form to cover their eyes. Sharks also have a very good sense of smell, and they can hear things from far away. All of these talents contribute to a shark's ability to be an excellent hunter.

Although most of us do not want to ever come face to face with a shark, we first must remind ourselves that attacks on humans are extremely rare. In fact, sharks are much more likely to be afraid of us than we are of them!

Snow Forts

The first large storm to hit the city was always the best. Everybody would look out their front door to watch the snow swirl and drift above the porches. The snow piles in the parking lots were massive!

Phil and his friends made the most of these piles of snow. The first ones to get to the parking lot were able to select the best pile. They would dig holes and make large forts to take cover in. When the forts were complete, a friendly battle would usually take place.

Phil was the first one at the parking lot after one big storm. He started to dig out one of the tall drifts. Other friends came one by one and went with Phil's suggestion to look for the best spot. They took turns shifting and packing the snow.

Next, a few more kids came and worked on their own forts. Some were smart and formed blocks of snow to make their fort extra strong. They knew that Phil and his pals could toss balls of snow with great force, so they had to have a way to protect themselves. There was much laughter while everyone worked to ready their forts.

Before the forts were even complete, the first snow-packed ball hit Phil on his left arm. It didn't hurt. He guessed it came from the edge of the parking lot because he heard the snow crunch. He turned around and saw a girl run into a yard and hide. The challenge was met. The snow battle had started! The best fort would win.

Move-In Day PART ONE

The big day was finally here. Tony felt happy and apprehensive all at the same time. Despite challenges along the way, he had worked hard in school. As a result, he had been accepted to the college on the top of his list. Today, he would move into the dorm - the first step to the start of a new part of his life.

Tony and his mother packed the car with all the things he would need to live away from home. He had a small fridge, a microwave, snacks, clothes, blankets, a backpack, and much more. Tony was shocked when they got it all to fit into the small car. Then it was time to start the three-hour drive.

Tony had visited the large campus once before for a tour, but this time he would be calling the college

home. Poor Tony spent much of the drive in silence. He couldn't stop thinking about how he would have to forge new friendships with total strangers!

Tony and his mother finally took the turn to merge onto the college campus. They were first directed to the check-in spot. Tony got his key, and they drove to the drop-off location. When Tony and his mother found the door to his dorm room, it had a note tacked to it with the names Tony and Greg in large print.

It took no time at all to get Tony's belongings into his room. Just as he began to unpack, Tony thought he heard someone else lurking in the hallway.

Move-In Day PART TWO

Just as Tony opened the first box to unpack, another student burst into the room. Tony looked up and knew right away that it must be Greg. After some quick introductions, the two began unpacking all their boxes. They made their beds, set a small rug out on the floor, hung a mirror, and got their desks set up for the school year. Tony and Greg opted to share an extension cord to charge their phones and laptops. The once stark dorm room now looked great.

Tony's mother was so happy! Things were off to a solid start for her son. She could tell that Tony was finally able to relax his nerves. She gave him a hug and told him it was time for her to drive home. It would be smart to start her travel back before it got dark. She felt sad and happy at the same time.

As she exited the hallway, she heard laughter behind her. This made her smirk, and she was thrilled that Tony would be able to discover new friends. He was on the verge of a new part of his life - life as a college student.

The Sport of Golf

Golf is a club-and-ball sport in which you use several different kinds of clubs. The objective is to hit a small ball into a succession of holes in as few strokes as possible. Anyone can take part in the sport of golf, and it's a smart way to get your body in shape. You'll cover about five miles of turf in the process of walking 18 holes of golf.

There are strict rules for the game of golf and you may be handed a penalty if you break one of them. Extra swings, or strokes, can be added to your score. However, most people who engage in a golf match do so as a sort of hobby. Punishments are usually part of the game only when it's set up as a competition such as a golf tour.

It takes great precision and dedication to become good at the sport of golf. If you spend any time on the links, you'll discover that some holes are constructed to curve either to the left or the right. This makes it harder to get to the green where you must putt the ball into the hole. Just a small cup and a flag stuck into the turf.

A golf course also has obstacles to irk you. A sand trap or marshy body of water may be positioned so that it's even harder for you to hit your mark and par the hole. That's why it's not often that you hear of somebody getting a hole in one. Are you willing to give it a try?

The Walk Home

The sky had already darkened, and Donna felt stressed. She was expected to be back home by nine o'clock, and she didn't want to upset her mom. With a good walking distance still to go, she selected the fastest way to make it back to her house.

Donna turned left at the edge of the park and cut through some yards. Although it made it necessary to trespass, it was the shortest way to get home. There was a risk of danger, but for Donna that didn't offset the problem of being late.

Donna crossed through one yard safely, but as she passed through the second one, she heard the distinctive snarl of a big dog. A sense of panic began to pour through her whole body. Donna had no place

to go for cover. Then the dog began barking so Donna made a run for it. She darted swiftly and wildly from the yard to the sidewalk and the curb.

The sprint to safety was already a blur when Donna heard somebody yell sternly at the dog. She looked back and saw the dog whirl around and then run to an open door on the porch. It had been a close call with a very protective canine, and Donna knew she had been lucky. She started to forge ahead, but this time she would stick to the sidewalk. Late was better than unsafe.

Backyard Visitor

Martin wakes up each day before sunrise. After he has something good to eat like a cup of pineapple chunks, Martin likes to sit on his deck and watch the sun come up. In Portland, he can only do this a few months a year when it's not too cold outside.

One day, Martin looks across his backyard through the forest expecting to see the sun start to rise any minute. All of a sudden, Martin hears a strange sound and spots something move near the small shrubs that stretch from his garage to the edge of his garden. Martin thinks that it could be any variety of small animals who call Oregon home. He wants to get a close-up look, but he hesitates. He doesn't want to end up face to face with an angry skunk.

Martin walks carefully down the steps of the deck and starts to make his way across the small backyard. He is mindful not to startle the animal. Just then, the sun begins to pop up over the horizon, and Martin can now absolutely recognize the wild animal in the area of the shrubs. It's a porcupine!

He is glad that it's not a skunk, but Martin knows not to get too close. A porcupine can discharge sharp spines called quills into anything that comes into direct contact with it. Martin makes his way back to the safety of his deck. He is quite sure that he has had plenty of exploration for one morning.

The North American Porcupine

Porcupines can be found in many forests around the world, and that includes the area of North America. These animals can be found in most of Canada and in the north and west portions of the U.S.A.

These remarkable mammals mostly munch on plants. Porcupines are usually active when it's dark, but they can be seen in the early morning too. Porcupines tend to live alone, but they will share a den with other porcupines in caves or logs during the cold months.

A porcupine has fur and short but strong legs. Porcupines make a variety of sounds. Their superior vocabulary includes whines, snorts, and clicks. However, the thing that most people think about when it comes to a porcupine is its long quills, or spines,

that stick out from all over its body. Once you have seen these quills up close, they are hard to forget.

Some porcupines have up to 30,000 of these quills on them. If any of these quills are lost, there is no cause for alarm. A porcupine can quickly replace them. These spines have sharp tips on the end and a porcupine will use them to defend itself against an enemy. They can't exactly fire these quills at something or someone, but if another animal were to come in close contact with a porcupine, it could end up with these horrible quills stuck into its skin. If you have any charming pets who will not watch a porcupine from a distance, they could very well become targets. Then you will find yourself transporting them to a vet for help.

Cargo to the Arctic

Carmella and her staff had to pilot a large cargo ship. The shipment had to get to the Arctic as fast as possible. There were more than ten scientists stationed there. They were part of a two-year Arctic exploration project. There had already been three shipment postponements because of bad storms.

To prevent starvation and illness, the cargo ship transported a variety of goods. It would cart food and medical items. There was no time to spare. At first, Carmella's boss wanted to forbid her to go on the expedition. He said it was far too risky. Carmella informed him about how important the shipment was to the superior scientists stationed in the Arctic. Carmella's boss finally said yes.

Carmella and the rest of the ship's staff moved the goods from the garage to the ship. Then, they carefully charted their trip. Lastly, they checked the ship's communication instruments. Safety was a must!

Finally, the cargo ship set off on an unusually cold and foggy morning. The trip on the large ship was a difficult one. Windstorms swept across the cargo ship, and the deck took on tons of water. For a stretch of time, they found themselves traveling through an uncharted area of water.

When the ship finally docked at the exploration site, the men and women there yelled with excitement. They unpacked the shipment and rested to recharge before returning to their home port on the now mostly empty cargo ship.

Ed and His Harmonica

Ed was a talented man who could handle a variety of musical instruments. However, he was most skilled with the harmonica. One day, Ed came across a news story. It was about a program through the city arts department. The program director was looking for anybody who could instruct students on how to play the harmonica.

Ed thought it would be fun to work with students. He'd had some extra time on his hands since his recent retirement. Ed contacted the arts department. The woman who answered the phone was more than pleased. She reported that they had almost given up hope. It turned out that not too many people in the area were regarded as skilled with the harmonica. This knowledge made Ed sparkle with a sense of pride.

Ed learned that first he would have to be accepted by the arts organization. They would discuss his application and check to ensure that he was a good candidate for the job. After ten days, Ed got the good news. His application was accepted!

On the first day of lessons, Ed met with each student for forty minutes. The lessons took place in a remodeled portion of an old garage that was rented by the city arts program. With Ed's superior command of the harmonica, his targeted instruction would surely help the students to tackle the notes and melody at hand. It was a formula for success. In fact, the students would be ready for the glory of the stage in no time!

What You Should Know About a Tornado

A tornado is a complex event that often has harmful results. It is also called a twister because its strong winds rotate with such extreme force.

A tornado forms when mild and cold air collide during a storm. This trademark collision makes the atmosphere close to the Earth unstable. A destructive vortex of horizontal wind develops and anything or anybody in the area is in danger.

A tornado can come in different shapes and its size can vary too. A tornado may be a wide funnel-like formation or it may transform into a rope-like swirl. It can travel just a short distance or it can harness ample strength to cover many miles.

More than anywhere else in the world, a tornado is likely to form in the U.S.A. This national

phenomenon is sometimes invisible until the tornado picks up dust and objects in its path.

If a tornado travels in your direction, you may only have minutes or seconds to react. A tornado can hurl objects hundreds of yards in an instant. Neither a small item such as a floor plank nor an object as big as a forklift is a match for a tornado. If you hear about a possible tornado in your location, find a safe place at once. Forgo a carport, garage, or uncovered platform. A basement or a spot in the middle of your house is the most superior selection.

Even with radar, a tornado is very difficult to predict. Scientists still struggle to completely comprehend everything there is to know about a tornado.

The Remarkable Orca

Did you know that an orca, or killer whale, is a dolphin? Orcas are the biggest mammal in the dolphin family. Their trademark black torsos with distinctive white patches can make them easy to recognize.

Orcas are aggressive hunters that dine on a variety of whales, fish, birds, and squid. They can jump onto an ice mass and snatch a seal right from the edge. Orcas organize and hunt in pods or families. The pod, which can be as many as forty whales, box in their target much like some land animals do when they hunt. Orcas also work together to make gigantic waves which then flush, or force into the open, a seal from the shore. Scientists marvel at this collective and superior method of hunting.

Orcas also use a wide range of sounds to communicate. Each pod articulates its own kind of vocabulary with a special collection of sounds. These sounds can vary and resemble calls, whistles, or clicks. The sounds travel under the water until they hit an object in the area. When the sounds come back to the orcas, they use the sonar-like information to navigate and detect other ocean animals around them.

The orca has a lifespan range of 50-80 years and can be found in all the world's oceans. Most people will not get the chance to get up close to one in the wild, but we can all support the protection of orcas and work to ensure that they will still be found in our oceans hundreds of years from now.

The Garden Party

Doris worked hard each spring to construct a charming backyard adorned with beautiful garden beds. Although she was not a florist, she had a remarkable talent with plants and flora, especially organic rose plants. Each year she selected a wide variety of rose plants with an assortment of colors to transform her backyard. The white, red, orange, and pink rose plants would impart a lovely smell.

One year, Doris sat on a small bench in the area of the backyard just next to her trademark rose garden. She thought it would be nice if her rose plants could bring their glory to others as well. That's when it hit her! She would organize and host a garden party and invite people from across the city to spend a morning on tour in this magnificent portion of her backyard.

On the day of the party, Doris enlisted the help of her son and daughter. Together they pulled the large yard tent out of the garage and set it up next to the portico on the edge of the rose garden. Under the tent, they set up an arrangement of tables. This way the guests could marvel at the roses and partake of a small snack or drink in the shade.

The response to the garden party invitations was incredible. More than forty people filled the tent and backyard. Everybody remarked that the garden was impressive and attractive, especially the rose plants. However, for Doris, the best part of the story is that she saw a smile on face after face!

Snacking on Popcorn

Popcorn may just be America's most perfect snack. The crunchy fluffy corn bites generally go hand in hand with the concept of fun. Think about where you've munched on a bag of popcorn. Perhaps it was while watching a film, or it may have been at a sporting event, theme park, or another sort of gathering.

No matter what environment you were in when you last ate popcorn, chances are you did not hesitate to munch away. However, don't be concerned because you are not alone. Americans consume a crazy amount of popcorn. As a matter of fact, Americans gobble up more popcorn than any other place in the universe!

Popcorn is an adaptable food. It can be mixed with things like nuts, pretzels, or chips to make a special party mix. It can also come in a variety of shades and tastes. You may prefer it salty, sweet, buttery, or even full of spice. In the end, you can curb your hunger with any version of popcorn you want.

On a serious note, popcorn may even be good for you. That is, as long as you don't bathe it in butter. This first-rate snack is rich in fiber, and it has been used to reduce inflammation in the human body. Furthermore, scientists have discovered that the hull, or shell of the kernel, has a material in it that protects human cells. So, don't feel too bad the next time you grab a handful of popcorn and start munching away.

Spiders - Just the Facts!

Whether we like it or not, spiders are all around us. Let's just consider that there are a lot of interesting facts to learn when it comes to spiders. However, there are some misunderstandings too.

Most people think spiders are insects, but they are not. Insects have three body segments, or parts. Spiders have only two. Also, insects have six legs, but spiders have eight.

There are many different kinds of spiders - almost 40,000 to be exact. Spiders are found in every environment and on every continent except Antarctica. Most spiders don't bother or cause serious harm to people. In more than one circumstance, spiders can help humans quite a bit.

Did you know that spiders consume harmful insects? They also pollinate plants and help recycle animal materials back into the Earth. Moreover, a number of small mammals, birds, and fish depend on spiders for their dinner.

Spiders usually live for a period of just one year. They develop webs to catch their food. A spider will make silk in its belly then spin this material into a perfectly patterned web. It usually takes about sixty minutes to generate a sturdy web. Many of these web spiders start from scratch and remake their web every day. It's a never-ending operation. Abandoned spider webs are called cobwebs. Perhaps you've had experience with one or two?

The Island of Pink Sand

Bermuda is a very small island nation. It can be found in the North Atlantic Ocean. The island is considered part of the North American continent and is made up of over 150 smaller islands and rocks.

Bermuda functions under British ownership but has its own government. It was discovered by accident in 1609. That's when a British ship crashed off its shore.

The capital of Bermuda, a city called Hamilton, is a small city filled with energy and extremely friendly people. Hamilton sits in the center of Bermuda and offers a number of shops, hotels, banks, and other establishments.

Planes and ships enter and exit Bermuda every day. They transport happy vacationers to and from the island. It's often the pink-sand beaches that attract visitors from all over the world. The perfectly pink sand is a result of coral, microscopic ocean material, and crushed shells mixing together as they wash up on shore. Not all of the sand found along Bermuda's shores is pink. However, each spot has something nice to experience.

The period from May to September is a good time to visit the island. It's a great time of year to interact with the soft carpet of pink sand during your stay. It's also a perfect time to consider whether you want to sunbathe, swim, or dive in the waters off Bermuda.

A Trip to the Netherlands

When Bert unexpectedly hears from his longtime friend Nick, he is thrilled by the surprise. It's been quite a while since they last connected. Nick had moved to the Netherlands a number of years ago to work in the energy industry. Now, Nick has interesting, but serious, plans to propose to Bert.

Nick asks Bert if he'd be interested in traveling to the Netherlands to visit him. Bert instantly says yes and starts gathering material and information about the Netherlands as soon as he terminates the call with Nick. Both Bert and Nick will be able to take ten days off from work in April, so there's a lot to plan.

Bert will fly into Amsterdam, the capital of the Netherlands, where he will reunite with Nick and begin their Dutch travel experience. While in the city, the

two friends will waste no time. They will hop on some bikes and explore the rich urban life that Amsterdam has to offer firsthand. After a tour of the canal, Nick and Bert will travel north through the suburbs. With cameras in hand, they'll spend some time in the Netherlands' rural environment to observe windmills and visit public gardens and national parks. Bert learns from his clever fact finding about Netherlands' famous tulips, so he makes reservations for a helicopter tour.

Bert and Nick plan to visit several other significant Dutch spots during their time together. The friends want to be sure to make this once-in-a-lifetime trip one to always remember.

Henderson's Buttermilk Bakeshop

Marjory Henderson and her husband, Dexter, have started a new period, or chapter, in their lives. It's a partnership established around Marjory's serious love of desserts. She's a dessert expert!

Marjory and Dexter have opened a bakeshop. It's called Henderson's Buttermilk Bakeshop. Marjory does all the food preparation, and she has a lot of energy, so she handles the customers, too. Dexter has experience with operations, so he works feverishly to make sure everything runs perfectly. Because of him, they have been able to generate big profits.

Marjory's desserts are a hit with the public. The best dessert she makes is something called butterscotch buttercups. In addition, the zesty

gingered cupcakes, paper-thin butter wafers, and potent peppermint cakes are also huge successes. The crunchy nut clusters are in big demand as well.

Recently, Dexter suggested they start selling sherbet and frozen yogurt during the summer months. Marjory thinks it is a superior plan!

The environment at the bakeshop can be hectic, but that's a good thing because it's customers that make things hop. In December, Marjory and Dexter hope to set up a delivery option for customers who can't make it to the shop to pick up their festive desserts. They just have to decide who will be doing the delivering!

The Butterfly Preserve

Robert opened his butterfly preserve more than thirty years ago. Since then, this protected open space in the suburbs has attracted not only an immense butterfly population, but visitors as well. People come from all over to experience the beautiful setting.

Robert worked with clever wildlife experts to ensure the land was transformed into the perfect environment for a butterfly preserve. Native plants, trails, and benches can be found throughout the property.

You can catch a butterfly hanging out in the pine, juniper, and cypress trees on Robert's preserve before they migrate south for the winter. Cold winters are not what they prefer. A butterfly will travel west or

fly somewhere like Mexico to escape the bitter winter period. After overwintering somewhere in a more tropical place, they will return to Robert's preserve once again.

Robert's daughter, Ellen, also works at the butterfly preserve. She will take over one day when Robert decides it's time to retire. The preserve gets no government funding, but donations from visitors and contributions from the public help the protected land survive. In turn, these offerings help beautiful winged insects thrive.

What About Those Carrots?

Each year, Americans snack on about twenty cups of carrots per person. That's a lot of crunching on this terrific orange vegetable!

Of course everyone knows that carrots are orange. However, purple, red, white, and yellow carrots also exist. People all across the world consume carrots. Why? Carrots are a great source of fiber, vitamins, and several kinds of minerals. The orange color, or beta carotene, of the carrot is converted to vitamin A once it enters the human liver. Why is this important? The digestion of vitamin A helps our vision, skin, and bones. It can also reduce the risk of terrible illnesses, even cancer.

Cooking carrots brings out more of the benefits than munching on them fresh from the garden. That's correct. You'll get even more than good taste when you bake, grill, or toss carrots in a pan. Interestingly, when you cook a carrot, tiny hidden pockets of the beta carotene emerge. Carrots have a lot to offer. However, I am sorry to say that it turns out that 88 percent of a carrot is water!

You may still conclude that you must include this fresh vegetable in your everyday menu. However, there's no hurry to stock up. Carrots are widely found all across the planet. They are a simple crop to plant and harvest. They even taste better after a frost or two.

Back on Track with Math

Mrs. Herring was correcting math papers at the library when she was interrupted by someone standing next to the table. It was Sherry, one of her students. Sherry said, “Excuse me,” to her instructor, Mrs. Herring, “may I talk with you for a moment?”

“How can I help you, Sherry?” asked Mrs. Herring.

Sherry began to narrate her tale. “I’m sorry, but I am having a terrible time in your math class, Mrs. Herring,” said Sherry. “I can’t understand any of the problems you give us, and I get only a few of them correct. It’s horrible.”

“Well, Sherry, it takes a lot of work, but there are resources to help,” said Mrs. Herring. “And of course,

I know you can do it. Trust me. This problem is going to only temporarily be a source of stress for you.”

That’s when Mrs. Herring offered to give Sherry extra help with the most recent chapter in the math textbook.

“Let’s get together here at the library one or two days each week. We’ll get in some extra math time,” suggested Mrs. Herring. “We’ll get you back on track in no time at all!”

Sherry was ever so thankful for the offer. “You’re terrific, Mrs. Herring,” she said. “The best!”

Mrs. Herring laughed and told Sherry she’d see her the next day in class. “And don’t be late,” she called as her student was hurrying out the door.

The Force of a Hurricane

A hurricane is a kind of severe tropical storm. It often forms in the Gulf of Mexico or the Atlantic Ocean. A tropical storm becomes a hurricane when the winds are stronger than 74 miles per hour.

Hurricane winds spin around a center called the eye. The eye of the storm itself is silent and still. However, just beyond that is the eye wall. This is a source of terrible winds, immense clouds, and blasting rain. There is no comparison between the center of the storm and the area just outside the center.

Most hurricanes are harmless because they never get close to land. They stay far out over the ocean waters. However, if a hurricane's course moves in the direction of land, there may be destructive

consequences. First, hurricanes can produce a short-term, but intense, storm surge. This happens when strong winds carry ocean waters in the direction of the shoreline. The water levels rise and develop large crashing waves. These waves barrel onto the land with a force great enough to smash everything in their path.

Although a hurricane tends to lose strength as it passes over land, the danger is not over. Harmful winds, floods, and even a tornado can still occur. If you find yourself in the path of a hurricane, it's best to hurry up and prepare and even depart when ordered!

Before, During, and After a Hurricane

There are things you can do before, during, and after a hurricane in order to protect yourself. Even before a hurricane hits, ask yourself this important question, “Is my home a safe place to be during a hurricane?” If your home will not stand up to hurricane-strength winds, then plan on going to a government shelter. This could be a place such as a public school or library.

Of course, watch the news reports closely. This way, you will have all the up-to-date information about the storm’s path and expected strength. Carry all the items in your yard, such as trash barrels and tables, into the garage. Otherwise, you’ll be sorry if they become harmful flying objects picked up and tossed around during the storm. Then, stock up on food, water, and dry clothes.

Flashlights or portable lanterns should also be on your list of necessary resources. In addition, it's good to always have an extra battery or two!

During a hurricane, you'd be correct if you think the most important thing you can do is plan to be inside. Stand far back from any windows and doors. In case terrible flooding occurs, be sure you have a way to get up to your attic and onto the roof in a hurry.

You must be on alert even after a hurricane hits. Rain and floods can carry on for days. Don't plan on going for a drive right away. Electrical lines may be down and streets may be littered with junk from the storm. Mostly, be willing to accept that it will take a while for things to get back to normal.

Cara's College Plans

Cara wanted to attend a large, diverse university. She had to complete an online application for the schools she was interested in attending. For some of the schools, she also had to register to take an entrance exam.

Of course, Cara knew the college-level curriculum would be difficult. However, she wanted to go to college just like her older sisters had done. Cara didn't want to stumble with the process. She knew she had to study hard and with purpose. She could not miss any necessary steps along the way.

Cara had to include several original paragraphs in her online application. Specifically, she was asked to make comparisons of two modern historical texts. She had to paraphrase and compare the texts and could

use other resources to help support any themes she was defending. Cara put together her thoughts. She felt that she did well on this portion of the application. Her passion for historical source topics helped.

However, Cara didn't feel as confident about the entrance exam, especially the math. Some of her friends who took the exam early had already told horrid tales to their classmates. So, Cara asked her friend to help her iron out some of the basics in order to prepare. They met at the library five times. On the test day, Cara was in a state of total concentration. The preparation had paid off.

In late March, Cara got several college acceptance envelopes in the mail. As she wished, Cara was able to attend a large university the next fall!

The Grand Canyon State PART ONE

Do you think about barren deserts and cactus plants when someone mentions the state of Arizona? That would be understandable. Yet Arizona is so much more!

The arid Sonoran Desert covers a large part of Arizona. The distinctive plants and animals of this desert have adapted. They thrive in extreme heat, lack of water, and terrible winds that sometimes strike.

What about the rest of the state? Interestingly, almost twenty-five percent of Arizona is home to dense forests. In fact, the ponderosa pine forest in Arizona is thought to be the most expansive stretch of this specific kind of tree in the whole world. Much of Arizona's forested land extends across mountains and

vast canyons. Visitors from all over camp and hike throughout the state and national parks.

The state is also a terrific source of mineral resources such as copper, gold, silver, and gravel stone. Crops such as cotton and melons thrive. The livestock industry prospers in this dynamic territory. In addition, Arizona is home to a wide variety of animals and plants. In comparison to all other states in the U.S., Arizona has the most examples of rare plants.

Of course, when you ask people what their purpose is in visiting Arizona, the most common answer heralded is seeing the Grand Canyon.

The Grand Canyon State PART TWO

Who could blame anyone for wanting to make a trip to Arizona to see the magnificent Grand Canyon? It's one of the most terrific places on Earth.

Grand Canyon National Park is massive. Looking to some like an apparition, the territory spans an incredible 1,904 square miles. The depth of the canyon itself is over one mile in some spots, and it can stretch as far as ten miles across.

The thermal differences in the canyon are extreme. You could be in sweltering summer conditions at the bottom of a gorge. While in stark comparison, the North Rim of the canyon can produce a shivering winter experience.

There are close to 1,000 caves within the Grand Canyon where fossils and historic artifacts have been discovered. Of course, that's not the purpose of most

people's visit. They come to take a caravan tour or embark on an extended hike. They want to surrender to the unmatched charm, majestic wilderness, and earthly resources.

Arizona is also the source of a diverse population of people. The American government recognizes over twenty Native American tribes living in Arizona. There are many events and places open to the public if you want to step back in time and learn about the endless contributions of Native Americans in this territory.

Lastly and incredibly, Arizona is the only place in the U.S. where you can temporarily stand in four states at once. That's correct! It's the intersection where the borders of Colorado, Utah, New Mexico, and Arizona come together. Who doesn't want to experience that and everything else in the Grand Canyon state?

The Sunshine State

The state of Florida is a peninsula. Thus, it's a portion of land that sticks out from a major land mass. It has water around most of it. The Gulf of Mexico is to the west. While on the other side of the state, you can take a swim in the Atlantic Ocean.

Florida has plenty of wildlife. Mammals such as armadillos and Florida panthers run wild. Reptiles such as alligators, lizards, and snakes also live there. In addition, hundreds of kinds of birds exist within the state. You can spot many of these animals in the Everglades National Park. Of course, Florida also has quite a bit of ocean life. On a regular basis, you can watch dolphins and turtles splashing in the waters and harbors of Florida.

There are hundreds of different kinds of Florida trees, however, the most favored one is the orange tree. Florida provides flavorful oranges for most of the orange juice sold throughout the U.S.A.

Florida is an extremely popular vacation spot. It has an expansive shoreline, a large number of golf courses, and many theme parks. You don't have to search too far to find something to do. You could even research a particular era of space exploration at Cape Canaveral! While you're there, you could see a rocket go skyward if you're lucky.

Florida has about 230 days per calendar year with sunshine. So, with all that regular solar presence, you can probably figure out why it's called The Sunshine State.

Tales of Tropical Horrors

Harper knew about the move to Florida even before her mom and dad told her. Her dad's boss had asked him to transfer to a new store in the Sunshine State and he could not refuse. Harper had spent all of her eleven years in Denver. She was going to miss the mountains and the color of the winter sky.

Harper's mind ran wild with crazy thoughts. She'd heard rumors about Florida and the tropical horrors she'd find there! There were bugs. Not your standard-size ones either. Huge bugs! Spiders and caterpillars were similar in size to a human fist! There were also massive lizards and alligators that hung out in people's yards on a regular basis. Plus, hurricanes formed in the Atlantic and Gulf of Mexico. Harper had

to figure that even a harbor could not fully protect you from the blast of a hurricane. Would their new house be secure? Would it all be terrible so close to the equator?

Harper talked to her mom and dad. “Florida is very different from Denver,” Harper’s dad told her. “But, do me a favor. Consider these particular facts. Florida has beautiful tropical plants, endless sunshine, and a variety of water sports you can try. Hurricanes are bad, but it’s rare for them to strike land. Don’t focus on the tropical tall tales and strange theories you are hearing from others. Florida will be great. You’ll make new friends and have fun. I just know it!”

Reptile Relatives

Alligators and crocodiles are close relatives. That's why it can be difficult to figure out which one is which. These reptiles look very similar. However, if you are someone who researches reptiles, you would quickly recognize them. You, too, can learn to detect some small differences.

Let's take a closer look. Alligators have a wide nose in the shape of the letter u. Crocodiles have a slim nose in the shape of the letter v. Both of them have a lot of teeth. However, you can't see an alligator's teeth when it shuts its mouth. On the other hand, a crocodile has teeth that are always visible.

Both alligators and crocodiles live around water. Crocodiles prefer salty water while alligators search for freshwater.

Both are carnivores, snacking on other animals. An American crocodile tends to grow longer than an American alligator. These crocodile males can be 13-16 feet, but the alligator males come close to that size at 9-15 feet. Because an alligator is often smaller, it would generally win a race on dry land. Finally, alligators tend to be darker in color than crocodiles.

The differences between alligators and crocodiles may be minor in some instances, but there are a lot of specifics that make one stand out from the other. If you ran into either one of these reptiles, could you now figure out which one it is?

A Stellar Traveler

Isabella had been to all seven continents, but for years had harbored hopes for something more. She wanted to figure out a way to travel to the stars - not just in theory, but to really explore the worlds beyond planet Earth.

In her efforts to become a spacecraft pilot, Isabella had come up against intense competitors. However, Isabella was among the best in her class at the space academy, and today she'd pilot a rocket ship into space.

For months, Isabella had been banking on her excellent memory, intelligence, and research to understand the rocket protocols. Besides flying the

ship, she had to monitor hundreds of switches and gadgets on the pilot's console.

After months of preparation, it was time for her to blast off. Isabella was able to secure herself in a tiny rectangular space, yank down her visor, and check on her copilot. There was no time to think about the horrors of a mistake during takeoff. She was singularly focused on all she'd learned.

The rocket began to shudder and shake and an explosion hurled the rocket upward. Isabella sank into the massive tug of gravity. Then, suddenly, the sky was a starkly black color and planet earth, hanging in the dark, shone like a gem. She'd done it! Isabella was now an interstellar traveler.

The Solar Inventor

Oscar was called a mad scientist by many, but he did not care. His mission in life was not to be popular. Rather, Oscar had a fervor for inventing things, and he was solely focused on solar products. He was positive that the Sun's energy could be harnessed in endless ways to help both humans and planet Earth.

Oscar set up a lab in sunny Arizona - the perfect place to work on inventions run by the Sun's energy. Each day of the calendar, Oscar worked with vigor from sunrise to sunset. If he wasn't doing research, he was testing out his next theory. Oscar was always developing new equipment and constructing models of his products. In the end, his ardor for the Sun's power had a serious purpose. Two of his inventions were on the market, and online sales were favorable.

The first successful solar product for Oscar was a solar lamp that could produce enough shine to light up an entire backyard for more than ten hours. His second product was even more impressive. Oscar had invented a solar watch. It told time without the requirement of a battery. Oscar's list of solar theories was long. Nobody knew what he'd be up to next, but he hinted that it might have something to do with solar panels to match any color.

For Oscar, success did not equal how many dollars he made. Rather, his definition of victory was inventing products that would both preserve the beautiful planet Earth as well as help humans access resources and secure a high standard of living.

Texas Horned Lizard

Have you ever heard of the Texas Horned Lizard? It's the state reptile of Texas, but this lizard can also be found if you search for it in places like Oklahoma, Kansas, New Mexico, and parts of Mexico.

A Texas Horned Lizard is sometimes called a horned toad because of its similar-looking body and the two horns sticking out of the back of its skull. Also covered in spines, a Texas Horned Lizard is often the color of the land around it - gray, tan, and brown. Despite looking less than favorable to pet, adult Texas Horned Lizards only develop to be about five inches long.

Texas Horned Lizards hide out and sleep during the winter months, so when they wake up, they are hungry. Texas Horned Lizards will consume all kinds

of insects, but they prefer a savory snack on a singular kind of insect - ants. They must like the flavor a lot because you can often find a Texas Horned Lizard resting right next to an anthill - ready and hopeful!

Sadly, if you monitor the population of these reptiles, you will find that it is shrinking. One theory for this reduction in the number of these lizards is the destruction of their environment. Even while we try to figure out the major factors of this problem, these lizards will carry on being quite popular. They've even been the focus of a grand story about a particular lizard with the name Old Rip who turned up alive after several haphazard events. The story is full of rumors, errors, and imposters, but humor can be found in it all the same.